

# Expertise Boundary Clinic Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Cross-AOK • 30-40 min

|            |           |      |                           |
|------------|-----------|------|---------------------------|
| Category   | Cross-AOK | Time | 30-40 min                 |
| Difficulty | Medium    | ID   | expertise-boundary-clinic |

Big idea: Expertise is powerful evidence within boundaries, but those boundaries must be identified.

## Overview

Students decide when expert authority should be trusted, challenged, or limited across different knowledge claims.

## Student Prompt

Inspect Expertise Boundary Clinic Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

## Concrete Stimulus Packet

|                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Expertise Boundary Clinic Stimulus A</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 1: Expert: climate scientist; claims about atmospheric data, energy policy, election strategy, and personal lifestyle choices. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply. | Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.                                                                  |
| <b>Expertise Boundary Clinic Stimulus B</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 2: Expert: novelist; claims about narrative technique, historical fact, psychology, and moral value. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.                           | Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.                                                                                          |
| <b>Expertise Boundary Clinic Reveal / Twist</b> | Student-facing stimulus 3: Expert: novelist; claims about narrative technique, historical fact, psychology, and moral value. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.                           | Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Expertise is powerful evidence within boundaries, but those boundaries must be identified. |

## Actual Lesson Questions and Key

| # | Question for students                                                                      | Teacher key / cue                                                                                             |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | After inspecting Expertise Boundary Clinic Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim? | Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.                                                  |
| 2 | Which exact detail from Expertise Boundary Clinic Stimulus A did you use as evidence?      | Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues. |
| 3 | What did you infer beyond the evidence?                                                    | Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.                       |
| 4 | How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?                                   | Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.                                                 |
| 5 | What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?                           | Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.                                    |

| # | Question for students                              | Teacher key / cue                                                                    |
|---|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 6 | When is expert authority a good reason to believe? | Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue. |

## Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how expertise is powerful evidence within boundaries, but those boundaries must be identified.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

## Setup Checklist

- Create expert cards that include real strengths and clear limits.
- Include claims that are inside, adjacent to, and outside the expert's domain.

## Ready-to-Use Examples

- Expert: climate scientist; claims about atmospheric data, energy policy, election strategy, and personal lifestyle choices.
- Expert: novelist; claims about narrative technique, historical fact, psychology, and moral value.

## Suggested Timing

| Stage   | Teacher move                                                                    | Watch for                                                                   |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1       | Give groups an expert profile and several claims the expert might make.         | Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.      |
| 2       | Students decide which claims fall inside, near, or outside the expert's domain. | Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.      |
| 3       | Groups identify what extra evidence would be needed for each claim.             | Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.      |
| 4       | Compare cases where expertise should carry more or less weight.                 | Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.      |
| 5       | Debrief responsible trust in knowledge communities.                             | Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.      |
| Debrief | Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.                      | Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming. |

## Teacher Language

- Respecting expertise includes knowing its boundaries.
- What would make this expert's claim stronger or weaker evidence?

## Common Misconceptions

- Students may apply one AOK's standard of evidence to all knowledge claims.
- Students may equate certainty with value or usefulness.

## Assessment Look-Fors

- Compares standards of evidence across at least two AOKs.
- Explains how a claim changes when method, context, or audience changes.

## **Differentiation and Adaptations**

- Support: use one expert and four claim cards.
- Challenge: include a conflict of interest or expert disagreement.

## **Extension Tasks**

- Students evaluate an expert source they might use for a TOK exhibition commentary.
- Compare expert authority in medicine, art criticism, law, and mathematics.

## **Related Activities**

- Reliability Ranking
- What Counts as Evidence?
- Peer Review Filter